

POWER OF THE MAGI

ancient Persian magic

In Persia, from around the 6th century BCE, Zoroastrianism developed under the Achaemenid empire. Its prophet Zoroaster (also known as Zarathustra) urged his followers to worship the supreme god Ahura Mazda. The world Ahura Mazda created became the arena of a struggle between Spenta Mainyu, the spirit of good, and his evil counterpart Angra Mainyu, marked by dark magic. Humans were free to choose their side.

The Magi were hereditary priests and specialists in Zoroastrian ritual who performed public and private ceremonies. Duties of the Magi included the *lan* sacrifice, which ensured the ruler's well-being, and tending to the sacred flame—the symbol of Spenta Mainyu—which burned in fire temples throughout the empire. There were terrible consequences for neglecting these duties. Greek historian Herodotus also refers to the Magi intoning over the flesh of sacrificial animals and interpreting dreams.

▼ Tending the fire altar

This Magus recites a ritual while standing before a fire altar. Making sure that the flame did not go out was his most sacred duty. If he did let it go out, he risked accusations of being a *daevayasna* (devil worshipper).



► Ready for ritual

Embossed on a sheet of gold, a Magus bears in one hand a cup of *haoma*, a mild intoxicant used in Zoroastrian rites, and in the other holds a *barsom*, the ritual bundle of twigs that represented the bounty of the vegetable kingdom.



Daevas and sorcerers

More information on the Magi comes from the *Avestas*, the sacred Zoroastrian texts. According to the *Avestas*, there were other divine beings called *daevas*, who should not be worshipped, but who nonetheless had devotees among the Magi known as *daevayasna*. *Daevayasna* included *yatu* (sorcerers) and *pairika* (witches). *Pairika* were at first believed to be supernatural spirits who sought to harm humans.

To protect against *pairika* the Magi could invoke the name of Ahura Mazda, or say prayers over clipped nails that were then buried. Ahura Mazda himself was believed to have told Zoroaster how rubbing the feather of the Varenjana bird against a Magus's body could ward off evil. In general, however, the Magi relied on ritual purity—keeping altars clear of pollutants such as excrement and dead matter—and a belief that stoking the sacred temple flame could kill a million *daevas*.

Accusations of *jadugih* (sorcery) were extremely serious for Persians. The accused could have molten metal poured over their tongue to determine guilt, while in the afterlife sorcerers were said to be consigned to infernal punishments such as having their bellies gnawed by dogs or standing for eternity on red-hot copper.

“It is not lawful to offer sacrifice unless there is a Magus present.”

HERODOTUS, *HISTORIES* 1.131, c. 430 BCE